



△ THE BIRTH OF GOTHIC ART

The basilica's choir, featuring tall, slim columns supporting a high rib vault with space for three stories of stained-glass windows, set the template for Gothic cathedrals throughout Europe.

Basilica of Saint-Denis

The 13th-century birthplace of Gothic architecture and burial place of France's kings

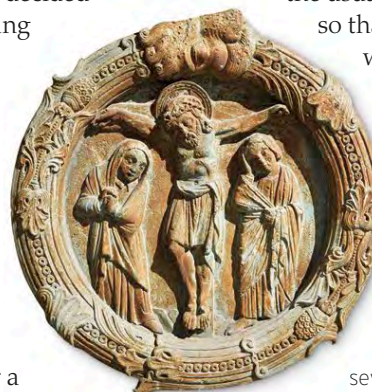


According to Christian tradition, St. Denis—the patron saint of France—was a 3rd-century bishop of Paris responsible for bringing Christianity to Gaul. His burial site, just outside Paris, became a focus of Christian pilgrimage, and the abbey-church built there in the 7th century grew into one of the richest in Europe. In 1135, Suger, the Abbot of Saint-Denis, decided to rebuild the church. He created a dazzling basilica in a new style, the Gothic, that would dominate European church architecture for the next three centuries.

A vision of light and space

At the church's west end, Suger built a 112-ft- (34-m-) wide facade with three doors, twin towers (the north tower was dismantled in 1846), and a rose window. At the east end, the chancel, built in 1140–1144, followed his vision for a

spacious church, flooded with light. For the first time, elements such as pointed arches, rib vaults, chapels radiating around an apse, and flying buttresses that allowed for the introduction of large, upper-level (clerestory) windows were brought together in a unified Gothic style. Moreover, Suger's architects replaced the usual heavy dividing walls with slim columns so that, as he himself put it, "the whole church would shine with the wonderful and uninterrupted light of most luminous windows." The light spilled through stained-glass windows to reflect on a golden altar and great jeweled cross, both later destroyed.



◁ SACRED SCULPTURE

This bas-relief of the Crucifixion is from the central portal at the west end, which features seven more roundels based on Christ's life.